

APFD-PV PADMANABHAM



WILD RIDE: One of the captured elephants from the wayward herd

getting the herd to return to its habitat is proving to be a mammoth task involving 15 trackers, two trained elephants brought from Andhra Pradesh and 20 beaters from Midnapore, West Bengal, to direct the elephants. "The biggest hurdle is to send them back through the non-forest areas through which they came," says A.V. Joseph, additional chief wildlife warden, Andhra Pradesh. Since elephants rely on their phenomenal memory to trace their way back, the herd has to cross villages where it caused considerable damage.

While Andhra Pradesh doesn't have a sizeable elephant population, Orissa's forests are home to thousands of pachyderms. But deforestation, encroachment, forest fires, establishment of power and irrigation projects and industries are fast shrinking their habitat. Poaching, especially of tuskers, also poses a serious threat to the population of these animals.

The mushrooming of illegal tribal hamlets is one reason why elephant herds strayed out of the Lakhari

sanctuary. There are as many as 16 such Saura tribal hamlets inside the forest. Trinath Nayak, member of the Lakhari Sanctuary Elephant Protection Committee, an organisation formed by the people living near the elephant reserve, says that the depletion—due to the cropping up of tribal settlements—of bamboo forests, which serve as an important food source for elephants, is forcing them to move out. He also feels there aren't enough water holes in Lakhari. With their habitat shrinking rapidly, the distraught animals have begun to migrate.

There has been a sharp increase in the number of incidents involving such human-elephant conflict. With further degradation and diversion of elephant habitats for human activities, there is clearly a need for studying and mitigating the growing conflict in eastern India, particularly Orissa, which has the largest number of elephants in the wild. Insightful and proactive measures and a holistic conservation strategy will have to be adopted to secure a future for what is one of the world's most exotic, intelligent and humble animal. ■

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